



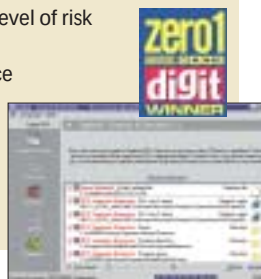
ANTI-SPYWARE

Unbeknownst to most PC users, information such as personal details, surfing habits, passwords and credit card information is at a high risk of being stolen from their PCs. How, you ask? It's spyware that's the culprit! Spyware are small applications that collect and push information to the developer of the application. In order to get rid of these pesky applications, you first need to get an anti-spyware software. That's where Spybot steps in to save the day.

PepiMK Software's Spybot is a comprehensive adware and spyware remover, at the best price ever—it's free! The installation is easy enough, and fairly quick. You get a warning telling you that removing some spyware may prevent some of your other software from functioning, or could go against their licensing policies. The program's layout takes a minute to figure out, but is very straightforward to use. Using all the default options, it quickly scanned for spyware, taking less than a minute on

Spybot

- + Shows possible level of risk associated
- Complex interface
- Price:** Free
- Web site:** spybot.eon.net.au
- Reviewed In:** July 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: NA
2001: NA

our test rig. The scan showed up 34 objects and listed them along with their paths. Clicking on an object brings up a comprehensive description of what type of spyware it is, the possible level of risk, what that program or file does to your system, and even an overview of the company's privacy policy. This is more than enough for you to make an

WORTHY MENTIONS

Ad-Aware

- + Good scanning speed
- Not much detail provided
- Price:** Free
- Web site:** www.lavasoftusa.com
- Reviewed In:** July 2003

Spy Sweeper

- + Fast installation, online definition updates, real-time protection
- Low scanning speeds
- Price:** \$29.95
- Web site:** www.webroot.com
- Reviewed In:** July 2003

informed choice of what to keep and what should go. In this regard, Spybot provides more information and makes it more accessible than any of the other tools tested here. The only spyware that Spybot missed were some elements of Kontiki, Cydoor and WurdMedia. Any spyware applications that are running during the scan are cleared out after a restart.

ANTI-VIRUS

Viruses are, by far, the most visible threats to PC security. Having the advantage of being among the first to affect computers, viruses have had that much more time to grab hold of the world's attention. Despite being so well known, many myths abound about what viruses and their lesser cousins are, and what they're capable of.

It's generally agreed that a virus is a piece of code that can self-replicate—make copies of itself automatically once it enters a host computer. The code doesn't have to do anything nasty to be called a virus. This is something a lot of people aren't aware of. In a way, the very fact that the program is multiplying on your computer without your knowledge may be termed malicious activity.

Once the top dog in the anti-virus industry, McAfee has had a rough time since mid-2000. No version of VirusScan available at the time was compatible with Windows Me. The 'poison pill' DAT file upgrades further reduced consumer confidence. Later versions had

McAfee VirusScan 7

- + One click updates
- Scheduling capability weak
- Price:** \$49
- Developer:** Network Associates
- Web site:** www.mcafee.com
- Reviewed In:** July 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: Norton Antivirus 2003
2001: Norton Antivirus 2001

the unfortunate propensity to corrupt Outlook Express e-mail messages, and were incompatible with Solitaire and FreeCell. Worse, certain versions had problems handling long file paths.

With version 7.0 though, all that is in the past. It turns out to be an all-rounder—providing good virus protection, one-click updates, a great

WORTHY MENTIONS

PC-cillin 2003

- + Great scheduling ability, low load on system, highly configurable
- Average scan scores
- Price:** \$49.95
- Developer:** Trend Micro
- Web site:** www.trendmicro.com
- Reviewed In:** July 2003

AVG 6.0 Free Edition

- + Free, easiest to use, least burden on the system
- No online support, below average virus scanning scores
- Price:** Free
- Developer:** Grisoft
- Web site:** www.grisoft.com
- Reviewed In:** July 2003

interface with oodles of aesthetic appeal, a very competent personal firewall and an amazing visual utility to trace the route to any Internet destination. As the winner of our best performance award, McAfee's back and it means business.